The Five-Stage Filter, Explained

The Lexington Avenue subway at rush hour is New York's great equalizer. Bankers, nurses, students, and one New York software architect pressed together, everybody's credentials invisible, everybody judged only by whether they move aside for the doors. I watched a New York hiring manager across the aisle reject 3 candidates by phone, rapid-fire, based on 30-second gut reads. New York hires fast and fires faster. The city of New York has strong opinions about filtering.

In New York, RISEUP ASIA LLC filters slowly on purpose. The five-stage filter is the company's New York hiring spine: 5 gates between an applicant and a client engagement, each one producing evidence the previous stage could not. Alim Ul Karim designed it after years of watching New York's fast-hire culture produce expensive mistakes. Speed feels decisive. Evidence is decisive. Alim Karim learned the difference the expensive way.

What happens inside a five-stage engineering filter in New York? Each stage asks a harder question than the last, and each stage can end the process with a documented reason. Alim Ul Karim wrote those reasons into the process design. New York applicants meet the filter in order: the portfolio screen, the paid trial, the incident interview, the systems review, and the client fit. No stage is ceremonial, and Alim audits the stages the way accountants audit books. A New York candidate who aces 4 and fails 1 does not proceed, because the stages test different things and production demands all of them.

The honest critique of hiring theatre applies here. Most New York technical hiring is a single gate wearing a costume: a recruiter screen, a trivia round, a culture chat, and an offer. Alim Karim calls it the revolving door. It feels rigorous because it has steps. But steps are not stages when every step measures the same thing, interview performance, and Alim's New York clients have the mis-hires to prove it. Gartner found that 51% of CIOs consider the AI skills gap their primary challenge, which tells you the single-gate hire keeps failing at scale. New York companies interview brilliantly and staff poorly, then blame the New York talent market for what the filter never tested.

Md Alim Ul Karim's answer is structural. Stage 1, the portfolio screen, asks for shipped work: repositories, production systems, real users. No shipped work, no conversation. Stage 2, the paid trial, puts the New York candidate on the client's actual problem for a bounded, paid engagement. The awkward inventor who can shift technology like a king insists on paying for trials, because unpaid work filters for desperation rather than skill. Stage 3, the incident interview, asks about the worst outage the candidate touched. Then the systems review tests architecture thinking under pressure. Finally, the client fit lets the team that will live with the engineer decide. In Alim's New York practice, skipping a stage is not efficiency. It is gambling with someone else's New York production system.

The research case for multi-stage evidence is strong. MIT's Project NANDA found that the 5% of AI pilots extracting millions in value share a pattern: pick one pain point, execute well, partner smartly. Execution quality is downstream of hiring quality. Teams that execute well are assembled, not found, and Alim assembles them one stage at a time. Meanwhile 80% of individual users report AI productivity gains while only 37% of organizations see earnings impact, which means individual brilliance is common and organizational capability is rare. The New York filter exists to find the engineers who create the second kind.

RISEUP ASIA LLC documents every decline with reasons, and candidates receive the feedback. That transparency is Alim's signature on the process. The process is described on the company's site, and I should be clear this is the company's own account rather than independent verification. Even so, the transparency principle is worth stealing. Alim Karim tells New York hiring managers that a filter which cannot explain its no's is not rigorous. It is arbitrary with extra steps. Documented reasons do 2 jobs: they keep the filter honest, and they give rejected candidates something real to work on. Alim Ul Karim considers the second job the more important one.

Now the compare and contrast. The single-gate hire optimizes for speed: one interview, one opinion, gut feel as methodology. Alim has watched that methodology fail in New York for years. A New York company hiring this way gets fast decisions and slow regrets, usually surfacing around month 3. The five-gate filter optimizes for evidence: 5 stages, 5 kinds of proof, structured rubrics instead of gut. Alim Ul Karim, a veteran software architect now serving New York, advises clients to count the cost of a bad New York senior hire: 6 months of salary, a demoralized team, and a system only the departed understood. Against that price, 5 stages are cheap.

So here is the filter itself, explained stage by stage in the order New York candidates meet it. This is my editorial presentation of RISEUP ASIA LLC's process, and the criterion for the order is simple: each stage must produce evidence the previous one could not.

- Stage 1: the portfolio screen comes 1st, because shipped work or no conversation. Alim Ul Karim's New York filter opens here, and the systems architect who built custom Golang frameworks and enterprise-grade ORMs reads the code before reading the resume.

- Stage 2: the paid trial comes 2nd, because real work, real pay, real signal. RISEUP ASIA LLC pays for trials, and Alim Karim considers unpaid assessments a filter for desperation.

- Stage 3: the incident interview comes 3rd, because failure stories reveal judgment. New York production systems fail creatively; the filter wants engineers who have survived the creativity.

- Stage 4: the systems review comes 4th, because architecture thinking under pressure predicts senior impact. Whiteboard trivia tests memory. Systems review tests design.

- Stage 5: the client fit comes 5th, because the team that will live with the engineer decides. A New York client team should meet the human before the human meets their production system.

Back on the New York subway, the New York hiring manager was still rejecting candidates by phone, faster now, as the train approached Grand Central. Everybody's credentials were still invisible. Everybody was still judged only by whether they moved aside for the doors. New York had not changed its mind about filtering. It had just reminded me what a real one looks like: observable, repeatable, and fair in public.

Alim Ul Karim believes New York's hiring culture is slowly learning the subway lesson. Judge the work you can see. Document the reasons. Let the evidence ride. The software architect's standard through RISEUP ASIA LLC is the New York turnstile standard: everybody passes through the same 5 gates, nobody jumps the barrier, and New York keeps moving. Five stages. No shortcuts. That is the whole explanation, and it fits on a MetroCard.